

Walking Aids and Gadgets for Arthritis UK: A Complete Guide

Complete UK guide to walking aids and daily living gadgets for arthritis. From walking sticks and rollators to kitchen aids and dressing helpers, with NHS and retail options.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-01-26 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

The right aids and gadgets can transform daily life with arthritis — reducing pain, conserving energy and maintaining independence. From walking sticks and specialised kitchen tools to clever dressing aids and home adaptations, there's an enormous range of products available in the UK. This guide helps you navigate the options, understand what's available through the NHS and find the best solutions for your needs.

Walking Aids

Walking Sticks

A walking stick is often the first mobility aid people consider. Properly used, a stick reduces the load on the affected hip or knee by up to **25%**. Important considerations include using the stick in the **opposite hand** to the affected leg (this is essential for proper biomechanics), getting the correct height (when standing upright with arms relaxed, the handle should be at wrist level), choosing an ergonomic handle (Fischer, palm or crutch handles distribute weight better than crook handles for arthritic hands), and using a ferrule (rubber tip) appropriate for the surface — spike ferrules for outdoor terrain, rubber for indoor use.

Nordic Walking Poles

Increasingly popular for arthritis. Using two poles distributes weight through the upper body, reducing lower limb joint loading by up to 30%. They improve balance and confidence outdoors, provide cardiovascular exercise simultaneously, and are available from outdoor shops and online (£15–£60).

Rollators (Wheeled Walkers)

For those who need more support than a stick. Modern rollators offer four wheels with brakes, a built-in seat for resting, a basket or bag for carrying items, and lightweight aluminium frames (some fold compactly). NHS provision is available through physiotherapy referral. Private purchase from mobility shops or online (£60–£300).

Wheelchair and Mobility Scooters

For longer distances or when walking is severely limited. NHS wheelchair services provide wheelchairs through referral. Mobility scooters are available privately (£300–£3,000+). Motability scheme leasing is available for those receiving PIP mobility component. Consider indoor vs outdoor use, portability and storage space.

Kitchen Aids



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The kitchen is one of the most challenging rooms for people with hand, wrist and shoulder arthritis. Key aids include:

- Jar and bottle openers — Under-cabinet mounted jar openers, rubber grip sheets and electric jar openers (from £5)
 - Ergonomic utensils — Large-handled, cushioned-grip cutlery, peelers and cooking utensils (OXO Good Grips range widely available)
 - Electric tin opener — Eliminates the twisting motion that aggravates hand arthritis
 - Kettle tipper — A cradle that tips the kettle for pouring without lifting
 - Tap turners — Lever attachments for traditional taps
 - Perching stool — A high stool for working at kitchen counters without standing
 - Lightweight pans — Ceramic or aluminium instead of heavy cast iron
 - One-handed chopping boards — With spikes and corner guards to hold food steady
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Dressing Aids

- Long-handled shoe horn — Avoids bending to put on shoes
 - Elastic shoelaces — Convert lace-up shoes into slip-ons
 - Button hooks — Help fasten buttons with reduced hand dexterity
 - Sock aids — A plastic gutter-shaped device that helps pull socks on without bending
 - Zip pulls — Large rings or tags added to zips for easier gripping
 - Dressing stick — Helps pull clothes over shoulders and push trousers down
 - Velcro fastenings — A tailor can replace buttons with Velcro on favourite garments
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Bathroom Aids



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- Grab rails — Essential for safety. Can be NHS-provided through occupational therapy assessment
 - Raised toilet seat — Reduces the depth of bending required. Available from £15
 - Bath seat or shower stool — Allows bathing in a seated position
 - Long-handled sponge/brush — Reaches back, feet and legs without bending
 - Non-slip mats — For bath, shower and bathroom floor
 - Lever taps — Replace twist taps for easier operation
 - Electric toothbrush — Reduces the hand movement needed for brushing
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Technology and Apps

- Voice assistants — Alexa, Google Home and Siri can control lights, heating, music and reminders hands-free
 - Smart home devices — Automated lighting, smart plugs and app-controlled heating reduce physical effort
 - Dragon NaturallySpeaking — Voice-to-text software for computer use with hand arthritis
 - Medication reminder apps — MyTherapy, Medisafe and NHS apps for medication tracking
 - Touch-screen stylus pens — Easier than finger tapping for those with hand pain
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Getting Aids Through the NHS



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Many aids are available free through the NHS via occupational therapy assessment. Ask your GP for an occupational therapy referral. An OT will assess your home and daily activities. They can provide (free of charge) grab rails, bath aids, raised toilet seats, kitchen aids, dressing aids, and mobility equipment. Some councils also provide aids through Adult Social Services. Delivery and fitting is usually included. The process typically takes 2–6 weeks from referral to assessment.

Where to Buy Privately

- Ability Superstore — Wide range of daily living aids online
- Complete Care Shop — Affordable aids with fast UK delivery
- NRS Healthcare — Comprehensive range of mobility and daily living aids
- Argos and Amazon — Increasingly stock ergonomic and adaptive products
- Local mobility shops — Try before you buy, with expert advice
- Disabled Living Foundation — Independent product reviews and advice

The right aids can make an enormous difference to independence and quality of life with arthritis. Don't struggle unnecessarily — even small gadgets can transform daily tasks from painful ordeals into manageable activities. Our virtual assistant can recommend specific aids based on your arthritis type and the activities you find most challenging.

This article is for general information only. Ask your GP for an occupational therapy referral for a personalised assessment of your needs.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about walking aids and gadgets for arthritis uk: a complete guide?

Short answer: Walking sticks reduce load on an affected hip or knee by up to 25%, while Nordic walking poles, used in pairs, can reduce lower limb joint loading by up to 30%. Rollators, available through NHS physiotherapy referral, offer more support with a seat.

Wheelchairs and scooters assist with longer distances. Many aids can be provided free via an NHS occupational therapy referral.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk